

CHARACINS AND RELATIVES

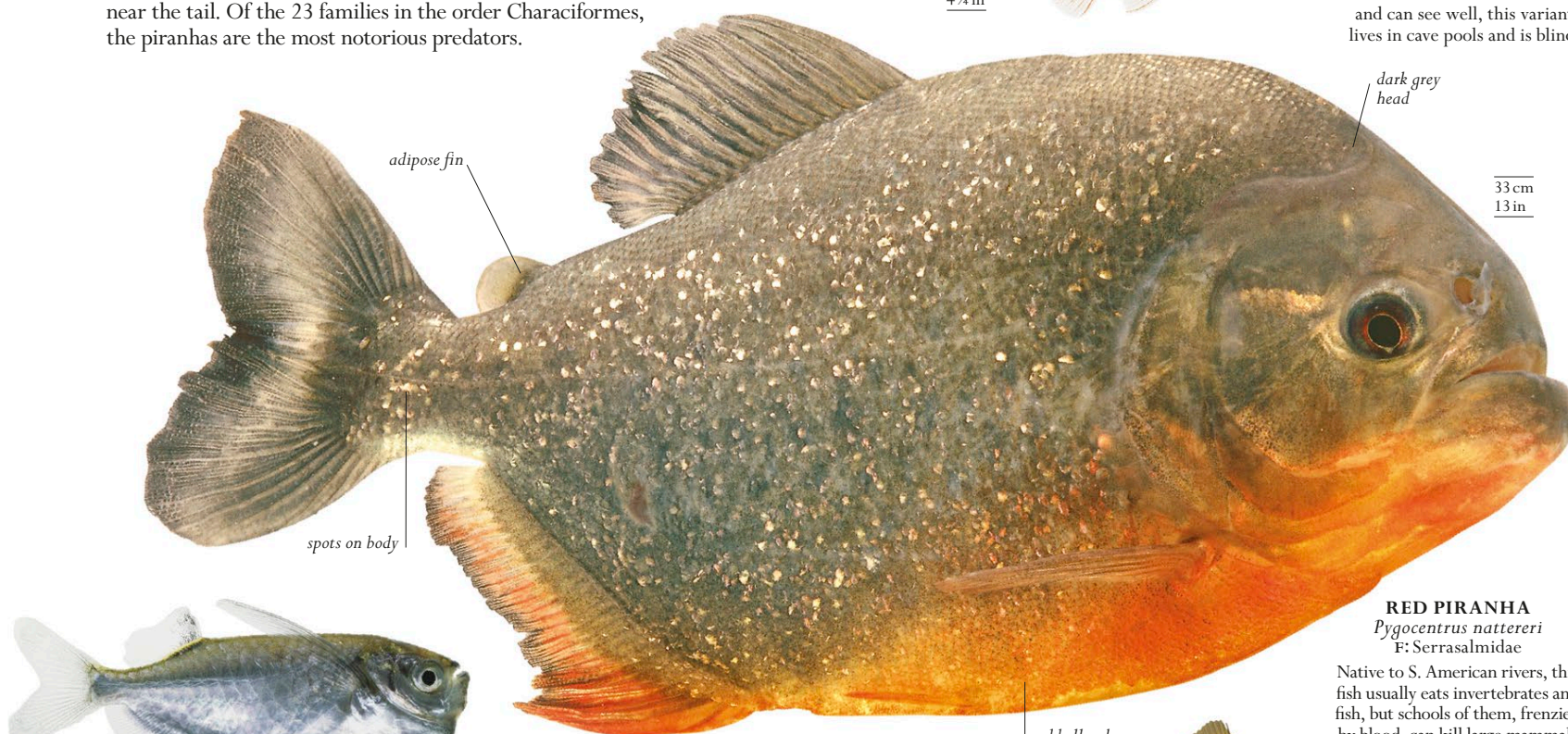
These freshwater fish are mostly carnivores, with well-developed teeth. As well as a normal dorsal fin, most also have a small, fatty adipose fin near the tail. Of the 23 families in the order Characiformes, the piranhas are the most notorious predators.



MEXICAN TETRA
Astyanax mexicanus
F: Characidae

While the normal form of the Mexican tetra lives in streams and can see well, this variant lives in cave pools and is blind.

12 cm
4¾ in



RED PIRANHA
Pygocentrus nattereri
F: Serrasalminae

Native to S. American rivers, this fish usually eats invertebrates and fish, but schools of them, frenzied by blood, can kill large mammals with their razor-sharp teeth.

dark grey head

33 cm
13 in

adipose fin

spots on body



6.5 cm
2½ in

RIVER HATCHETFISH
Gasteropelecus sternicla
F: Gasteropelecidae

This insectivorous S. American fish can leap out of the water to escape predators and to catch aerial prey.



TIGERFISH
Hydrocynus vittatus
F: Alestidae

Native to African rivers, this large predator has fang-like teeth and can eat fish half as long as itself.

1 m
3¼ ft



LONGSNOT DISTICHODUS
Distichodus lusosso
F: Distichodontidae

Unlike some of its piranha relatives, this is a peaceful herbivorous fish. It lives in streams in equatorial Africa.

40 cm
16 in

red belly when fully grown

CATFISH

The predominantly freshwater catfish have a long body and many whiskery mouth barbels used to help find food. There is a sharp spine in front of the dorsal fin. Most species in this order (Siluriformes) grub around on the bottom searching for algae and small invertebrates.



5 m
16 ft

SHEATFISH
Silurus glanis
F: Siluridae

From wetlands in C. Europe and Asia, this huge fish has been known to weigh over 300 kg (660 lb), but due to heavy fishing, none this size exists today.



32 cm
12½ in

STRIPED EEL CATFISH
Plotosus lineatus
F: Plotosidae

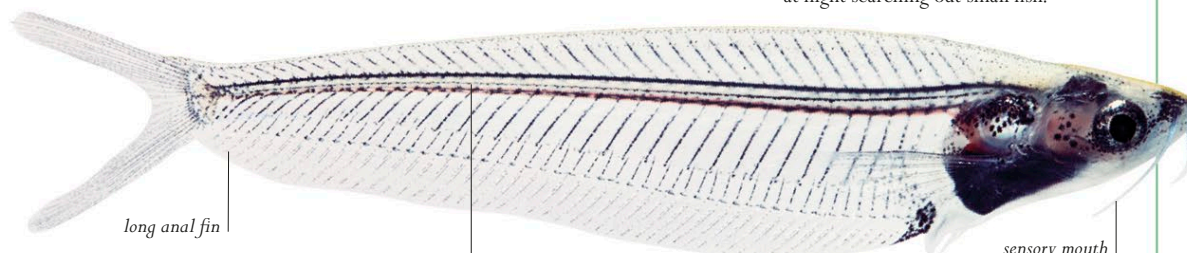
Juveniles of this tropical marine species form dense ball-shaped shoals for protection. Solitary adults defend themselves with their venomous fin spines.



1 m
3¼ ft

TIGER SHOVELNOSE CATFISH
Pseudoplatystoma fasciatum
F: Pimelodidae

The long barbels of this S. American fish help it find food as it hunts over riverbeds at night searching out small fish.



long anal fin

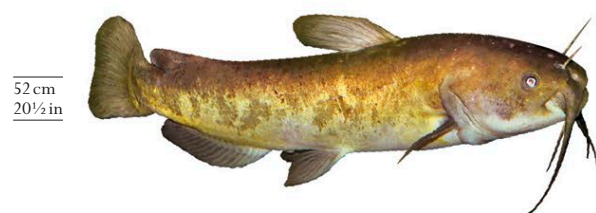
spine visible through transparent body

15 cm
6 in

GLASS CATFISH
Kryptopterus bicirrhus
F: Siluridae

A native of S.E. Asia, this small fish hangs motionless in the water; its transparent body makes it hard for predators to see.

sensory mouth barbels help find food



52 cm
20½ in

BROWN BULLHEAD
Ameiurus nebulosus
F: Ictaluridae

This N. American catfish has venomous fin spines that help ward off predators when it is guarding its nest.